Himaayah Schools
ACADEMY

FREE GUIDE

ن وَالْقَلَمِ وَمَا يَسْطُرُونَ ج

"Nūn. By the pen and what they inscribe." (al-Qalam 68:1)

JAMB Literature

A UTME study guide to Literature in English: the terms you must know, drama, prose and poetry, and a practice test.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Literature in English in the UTME tests two things: how well you know the set texts in drama, prose and poetry, and how well you understand literary terms and can apply them to unseen passages. Read the set texts themselves, more than once, and learn the vocabulary of literature until you can spot a device instantly. This guide gives you the syllabus, the terms you must know, worked examples, the traps to avoid, an 8-week plan and a practice test.

The UTME at a glance	
Subjects	Use of English and three subjects for your course. Literature in English is required or accepted for law, English, mass communication, theatre arts and many arts courses.
Questions	Use of English 60; each other subject 40; 180 questions in all, on computer (CBT).
Time	About two hours for all four papers, so roughly 40 seconds a question. You move freely between subjects.
Marking	Each subject is scored out of 100, for a total out of 400. There is no negative marking: never leave a question blank.

Check the official details

Exam rules and syllabuses can change from year to year. Always check the current JAMB brochure and the official Literature in English syllabus on the JAMB website or e-facility portal, and follow them where they differ from this guide.

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Part 1 The syllabus at a glance

Study from the **JAMB syllabus**, not only from your school notes: every UTME question comes from a topic on it. The topics fall into these areas:

Area	Topics
General literary principles	The genres (drama, prose, poetry) and their types; literary terms and devices; the relationship between literature and life
Drama	Set African and non-African plays; types of drama (tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce); dramatic techniques and devices; character, plot, setting, themes
Prose	Set African and non-African novels; narrative techniques and point of view; plot, character, setting, theme and style
Poetry	Set African and non-African poems; poetic forms; sound devices, imagery, tone and mood; literary appreciation of unseen poems and passages

The set texts change every few years. Check the current JAMB brochure and syllabus for your exam year, get the exact editions listed, and read each text in full at least twice. Summaries alone are not enough.

Part 2 The terms you must know

Figures of speech

Term	Meaning	Example
Simile	Comparison using “like” or “as”	Her voice was like music.
Metaphor	Direct comparison without “like” or “as”	All the world’s a stage.
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human things	The wind howled all night.
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration	I have told you a million times.
Oxymoron	Two opposite words side by side	Sweet sorrow; deafening silence.
Paradox	A statement that seems contradictory but holds a truth	The child is father of the man.
Irony	Saying one thing but meaning the opposite; or an outcome opposite to what is expected	A fire station burns down.
Alliteration	Repetition of the same consonant sound at the start of words	Peter Piper picked a peck…
Assonance	Repetition of vowel sounds	The rain in Spain…
Onomatopoeia	Words that imitate sounds	Buzz, hiss, bang.
Metonymy	Naming something by something closely linked to it	The pen is mightier than the sword.
Synecdoche	A part for the whole, or the whole for a part	All hands on deck.
Apostrophe	Addressing someone absent or something non-human	O Death, where is thy sting?
Euphemism	A mild word for something harsh	“He passed away” for “he died”.
Litotes	Understatement by negating the opposite	She is not a bad singer.

Poetry

Term	Meaning
Sonnet	A 14-line poem. Petrarchan: an octave (8) and a sestet (6). Shakespearean: three quatrains and a rhyming couplet.
Ode / Elegy	Ode: a poem of praise. Elegy: a poem of mourning for the dead.
Ballad / Epic	Ballad: a narrative song-poem in short stanzas. Epic: a long narrative of heroic deeds.
Blank verse / Free verse	Blank verse: unrhymed iambic pentameter. Free verse: no regular rhyme or metre.
Rhyme scheme	The pattern of end rhymes, written with letters: ABAB, AABB.
Enjambment / Caesura	Enjambment: a sentence running on to the next line. Caesura: a pause within a line.
Tone / Mood	Tone: the poet's attitude. Mood: the feeling created in the reader.

Drama and prose

Term	Meaning
Tragedy / Comedy	Tragedy ends in the downfall of the hero; comedy is light and ends happily. Tragicomedy mixes the two; farce is broad, exaggerated comedy.
Hamartia / Catharsis	Hamartia: the hero's tragic flaw. Catharsis: the audience's release of pity and fear (Aristotle).
Soliloquy / Aside	Soliloquy: a character speaks thoughts alone on stage. Aside: a remark to the audience unheard by other characters.
Dramatic irony	The audience knows what a character does not.
Protagonist / Antagonist / Foil	The main character; the one who opposes him; a character who highlights another by contrast.
Point of view	First person ("I"), third-person limited, or omniscient (all-knowing) narrator.
Flashback / Foreshadowing	A return to earlier events; hints of what will happen.
Novel types	Bildungsroman (growing up); epistolary (letters); picaresque (adventures of a rogue); satire (ridicule to correct); allegory (a story with a hidden meaning).

Part 3 Sample questions, explained

Example 1. "The wind howled angrily through the trees." The figure of speech is:
→ Howling angrily is a human action given to the wind.

Answer: Personification

Example 2. “It was a deafening silence.” This is an example of:
→ Two opposite ideas, “deafening” and “silence”, are placed together.
Answer: Oxymoron

Example 3. A poem of fourteen lines is a:
→ The sonnet has fourteen lines, in Petrarchan or Shakespearean form.
Answer: Sonnet

Example 4. A speech in which a character alone on stage reveals his thoughts is a:
→ That is a soliloquy; an aside is a short remark to the audience while others are on stage.
Answer: Soliloquy

Example 5. When the audience knows something a character does not, it is called:
→ This is dramatic irony.
Answer: Dramatic irony

Example 6. A novel told through letters is described as:
→ Epistolary comes from the Latin for “letter”.
Answer: Epistolary

Example 7. “Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers.” The sound device is:
→ The repeated initial /p/ sound is alliteration.
Answer: Alliteration

Example 8. The tragic flaw of the hero is called:
→ Aristotle’s term for it is hamartia.
Answer: Hamartia

Example 9. An unseen poem: “What is the tone of the poem?”
→ Look at the poet’s word choices: are they bitter, tender, mocking, hopeful?
→ Choose the option that fits the whole poem, not one line.
Answer: The attitude shown by the poet’s words across the whole poem

Part 4 Traps that cost marks

Trap	What to do
Reading only summaries of the set texts	JAMB asks about details: who said what, where and why. Read each text in full.
Mixing up simile and metaphor	Simile uses “like” or “as”; metaphor does not.
Confusing tone and mood	Tone is the writer’s attitude; mood is what the reader feels.
Using an old edition or the wrong text	Check the brochure for the exact titles for your year.
Irony versus sarcasm	Sarcasm is bitter, mocking irony aimed at someone; not all irony is sarcasm.
Ignoring the unseen passages	Practise appreciation of unseen poems and passages every week.

Part 5 An 8-week plan

Start at least eight weeks before the exam. Each week: learn the topics, make short notes and solve past questions under time. Keep one day a week for revision.

Week	Focus	Practice
1	Genres and figures of speech	Flashcards of all terms; 30 questions
2	Poetic forms and sound devices	Identify devices in 10 poems
3	Set drama texts: first reading	Notes: plot, characters, themes, quotations
4	Set prose texts: first reading	Chapter-by-chapter notes
5	Set poems: every poem in the list	Theme, tone and devices for each
6	Second reading of all set texts	Past questions on each text
7	Unseen poetry and prose appreciation	Two unseen passages a day
8	Full revision and mock exams	Two full timed papers

Exam-day reminders

Read every option before choosing. Eliminate the clearly wrong ones first.

Do not spend more than a minute on one question: flag it and come back.

Answer every question; there is no penalty for a wrong answer.

Check that your answers are saved before you submit, and keep an eye on the clock for all four subjects.

Test Practice test

Give yourself 10 minutes for these 15 questions, as in the real exam. The answers follow.

1. **"He is as brave as a lion" is an example of:**
   a) Metaphor b) Simile c) Personification d) Hyperbole

2. **"The classroom was a zoo" is an example of:**
   a) Simile b) Oxymoron c) Metaphor d) Alliteration

3. **A poem written in mourning for the dead is:**
   a) An ode b) A ballad c) An epic d) An elegy

4. **Unrhymed iambic pentameter is called:**
   a) Free verse b) Blank verse c) A couplet d) A quatrain

5. **The Shakespearean sonnet ends with:**
   a) A rhyming couplet b) A sestet c) An octave d) A refrain

6. **"Buzz" and "sizzle" are examples of:**
   a) Assonance b) Onomatopoeia c) Litotes d) Irony

7. **A story that grows up with its main character is a:**
   a) Picaresque novel b) Epistolary novel c) Bildungsroman d) Satire

8. **"All hands on deck" is an example of:**
   a) Synecdoche b) Euphemism c) Apostrophe d) Paradox

9. **The audience's release of pity and fear at the end of a tragedy is:**
   a) Hamartia b) Catharsis c) Hubris d) Denouement

10. **A character who sets off another by contrast is a:**
    a) Protagonist b) Narrator c) Chorus d) Foil

11. **A narrator who knows the thoughts of all the characters is:**
    a) First-person b) Omniscient c) Unreliable d) Limited

12. **"He passed on" instead of "he died" is:**
    a) Hyperbole b) Euphemism c) Irony d) Pun

13. **The pattern of end rhymes in a poem is its:**
    a) Metre b) Rhyme scheme c) Stanza d) Caesura

14. **A play that mixes tragic and comic elements is a:**
    a) Farce b) Tragicomedy c) Melodrama d) Masque

15. **Where do you find the current set texts for the UTME?**
    a) In the JAMB brochure and syllabus for your year b) In any old textbook c) On social media d) In last year's WAEC timetable

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Simile	9	b) Catharsis
2	c) Metaphor	10	d) Foil
3	d) An elegy	11	b) Omniscient
4	b) Blank verse	12	b) Euphemism
5	a) A rhyming couplet	13	b) Rhyme scheme
6	b) Onomatopoeia	14	b) Tragicomedy
7	c) Bildungsroman	15	a) The JAMB brochure and syllabus
8	a) Synecdoche		

Recommended textbooks

- The **set texts** in drama, prose and poetry named in the current JAMB brochure, in the editions listed.
- A dictionary of literary terms, such as **A Glossary of Literary Terms** by M. H. Abrams.
- Other texts listed in the current JAMB Literature syllabus.
- **Past questions**: solve at least the last ten years' UTME Literature in English questions, timing yourself, and study every one you get wrong.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Read the texts, know the terms.

This free guide from the Himaayah Academy helps UTME candidates prepare for Literature in English with every literary term the exam uses and a plan for the set texts.

- The Literature syllabus in four areas
- Fifteen figures of speech with examples
- Poetic forms, drama and prose terms
- Sample questions, explained
- An 8-week plan and a 15-question practice test

Prepare with the Himaayah Academy

Live UTME classes with a personal mentor, daily tasks, weekly mock exams and CBT practice, all online.

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